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A Timeless Inner World

Painting - A metaphor in response to a metaphor

In *IQ84*, the past is consistently connected to the present and the future through memory and feelings of familiarity. When such connections exist, the notion of linear time is called into question. Moreover, if time does not function as a force that drives events to occur, then events may already be determined before they take place. I argue that reality in *IQ84* is a reflection of the mind, where autonomy operates within a deterministic framework. The two moons in *IQ84* serve as a metaphor for the relationship between the mind and reality. Aomame is drawn into a world where her inner thoughts are mirrored by external circumstances. She comes to understand the coexistence of seemingly contradictory forces—determinism and autonomy—and ultimately leaves with a newfound certainty of belief. She returns to the world with only one moon, but with the assurance of Tengo's presence, as if returning to her rightful path. In response to this interpretation, I created a Chinese ink painting of a tree. I use this tree, composed of layers of leaves and blossoms rendered through shades and light, as a metaphor to represent the idea that reality reflects the mind.

Throughout *1Q84*, events are often linked to those of the past. While these connections may appear to result from chance, their accumulation invites consideration of the deeper relationships among past, present, and future. Among the countless scenes witnessed and moments experienced, certain instances are remembered and reappear later with striking clarity. If what is recalled is not random but determined, then its later recollection is already embedded in the original moment. In this way, the future is always taking shape at every point where one observes and reflects. These connections do not unfold in a linear progression but emerge spontaneously. For instance, readers may be surprised when Aomame recalls the little spiders that spun webs on the emergency stairway (Murakami 698). However, these spiders were already described earlier, when Aomame first climbed the stairway (36). She later remembers them again when she escapes with Tengo using the same stairs (770). Were the spiders remembered because they were seen, or were they seen in order to be remembered? If the latter is true, then the events on pages 698 and 770 were already written into Aomame's story before page 36. Time, in this view, may be linear—but in reverse—or perhaps all three events exist simultaneously. Aomame remembers and sees the spiders because it is simply in her nature to do so; her actions arise from who she is.

A hint of determinism lies within Aomame's character and behavior. The pen that draws already knows its drawing. If we consider Aomame as a representation of her thoughts and personality—her inner world—then her experiences are determined by who she is. Tengo's relationship with the air chrysalis offers another example. As the ghostwriter of *Air Chrysalis*, Tengo encounters events from the story in real life, including seeing two moons (936) and witnessing the air chrysalis (733). When he first sees the air chrysalis, he experiences “a violent sense of déjà vu” (733). The object appears exactly as he had imagined and described in the

manuscript (734). What Tengo envisioned becomes reality without alteration—his experience reflects a story born of his own inner world.

This inner world, unique to each character, shapes what they perceive and how they experience reality. What stands out to Aomame, like the spider, may not carry the same significance for the reader. Similarly, the air chrysalis holds particular meaning for Tengo as its author. Aomame names the new world “1Q84” (138), while Tengo refers to it as “a real town of cats” (720). Their perspectives are guided by their traits, which stem from their personalities and childhoods—factors that also determine their career paths, decisions, and even their attraction to one another.

The inner world, then, determines each person’s experience of reality. Unlike determinism imposed by external forces, this is a form of self-determination. People perceive with their own eyes; these perceptions shape their behavior, and accumulated behavior becomes identity. Although this process can be described linearly, it is also recursive. Because of its repetitive nature, the linear sequence becomes less meaningful. Just as a *maza* bears a *dota* in its image, a person forms identity through acts that only they can perform. As Aomame states, “Maybe it’s a paradox, like an image reflected to infinity in a pair of facing mirrors. I am a part of this world, and this world is a part of me” (1069). Her life is neither entirely predetermined nor random. There is a path within her—one that only she can sense. She need not search for it; it finds her, and she follows it with certainty.

Inspired by this idea—that reality reflects one’s inner thoughts—I created *Tree*, a traditional Chinese ink painting. Traditional Chinese landscape paintings often explore the relationship between mind and world through repeated patterns—such as those found on mountains—formed by light, shadow, and distance. My painting draws on these ideas while offering an original interpretation through the image of a tree. The painting conveys its message through the following elements:

Green and Yellow *Two Moons*

I chose to depict a tree at the transition between spring and summer, bearing both white flowers and green leaves. This color combination echoes the two moons—“the big, yellow moon and the small, green one” (737). The coexistence of flowers and leaves from different seasons suggests a collision of temporal states. Which comes first? Leaves follow flowers, yet also give rise to them again. This cycle implies simultaneity and challenges the notion of time’s progression.

Lighting and Shadow *Reality and the Mind*

Seen from a distance, two intersecting bands—one light and one dark—cross the tree diagonally, mirroring each other in shape and angle. This repetition is not a mere compositional choice but a deliberate visual metaphor for the relationship between reality and the inner world. Just as the bright band might suggest sunlight filtering through the leaves and the dark band might suggest the shadow cast in its absence, the two together create a dynamic contrast that symbolizes how external reality and internal perception coexist and reflect one another. They are opposites, yet they echo each other in structure, suggesting that one is shaped by the presence of the other. In this sense, reality becomes legible only through the contrast offered by the mind’s interpretation,

just as light is understood in relation to shadow. This visual interplay reinforces the thematic idea that the world is not separate from the individual but shaped by how the individual sees, remembers, and feels it. The tree, in this case, stands as a visual embodiment of Aomame's realization: that the world outside her is deeply intertwined with the world inside her.

Repetition *Maza and Dota*

Upon closer inspection, each bright and dark section divides further into smaller areas of light and shadow. These parts mirror the structure of the whole, illustrating the *maza-dota* relationship. Each small branch is a *dota* born of the larger *maza* tree. The tree does not grow arbitrarily; it follows a path determined by its form. Likewise, every *dota* in *1Q84* is born through a passageway. I interpret this passageway as the method or path that enables a *dota* to emerge from its *maza*.

Finally, in a broader sense, the tree grows along a natural course, as do Aomame and Tengo. The tree becomes a metaphor for all living beings shaped by the path of nature. Their realities are projections of their inner worlds, which, in turn, reflect their unique selves. Like Aomame's discovery of a path that is already within her, the painting expresses a truth that reality and identity grow in tandem—each branch an extension of self, each shadow cast by the mind. Through both literature and art, this essay argues that what we perceive as the world around us is, ultimately, a mirror of what lies within.

Works Cited

Murakami, Haruki. *1Q84*. Translated by Jay Rubin and Philip Gabriel, Knopf Doubleday Publishing Group, 2011. Kindle ed.